

CHEM&131: Introduction to Organic and Biochemistry

Fall 2026 (September 21 – December 10, 2026)

What's Covered

Everything covered in this course, organized by topic and week — useful for comparing against an equivalent course at another institution, and for previewing what's ahead before the term starts.

Built from the Fall 2026 Chemfolio schedule — first term using this material, so some groupings may shift slightly as the term settles in.

Week 1: Introduction to Organic Molecules and Alkanes

What this week covers:

- Characteristic features of organic compounds; drawing organic molecules
- Functional groups; alkanes and alkane nomenclature; cycloalkanes
- Fossil fuels, physical properties, and combustion of hydrocarbons
- Lab: Safety orientation; scavenger hunt covering compounds, shapes, and IMFs
- Required Reading: Smith Ch. 10 (10.1–10.10)

▼ Weekly logistics

- Activity: A21 (10.1–10.6)
- Activity: A22 (10.4–10.10)

Week 2: Isomers and Organic Naming

What this week covers:

- Organic structure and naming across functional groups (integrative, spanning Ch. 10–13)
- Constitutional and cis-trans (geometric) isomers; alkane/cycloalkane naming revisited
- Lab: Solubility and Oil Spills
- Required Reading: Smith Ch. 10 (10.5–10.8), Ch. 11 (11.1–11.4)

▼ Weekly logistics

- Activity: A23 (integrative — Ch. 10–13)
- Activity: A24 (10.5–10.8, 11.3–11.4)
- Writing Workshop 1

Week 3: Alkene Reactions, Polymers, and Alcohols

What this week covers:

- Reactions of alkenes; polymers; margarine vs. butter
- Alcohols and ethers — structure, properties, and reactions; alkyl halides; thiols
- Lab: Plastics and Nurdles
- Library Visit 1
- Required Reading: Smith Ch. 11 (11.5–11.7), Ch. 12 (12.1–12.7)

▼ Weekly logistics

- Activity: A25 (11.5–11.7)
- Activity: A26 (12.1–12.7)

Week 4: Oxygenated Compounds and Carboxylic Acids**What this week covers:**

- Aldehydes and ketones; oxidation of aldehydes; chirality (Looking Glass Chemistry); chiral drugs
- Carboxylic acids and esters — naming, properties, acidity, and reactions
- Lab: Chirality
- Required Reading: Smith Ch. 12 (12.8–12.12), Ch. 13 (13.1–13.6)

▼ Weekly logistics

- Activity: A27 (12.8–12.12)
- Activity: A28 (13.1–13.6)
- Also this week: Unit Quiz 1 (Ch. 10 + Ch. 11)

Week 5: Amines, Amides, and Protein Structure**What this week covers:**

- Amines and amides — structure, basicity, naming
- Amino acids, acid-base behavior of amino acids, and peptides
- Lab: Reactions of Functional Groups
- Library Visit 2
- Required Reading: Smith Ch. 13 (13.7–13.10), Ch. 16 (16.1–16.6)

▼ Weekly logistics

- Activity: A29 (13.7–13.10)
- Activity: A30 (16.1–16.6)
- Writing Workshop 2

Week 6: Proteins, Enzymes, and Carbohydrates**What this week covers:**

- Common proteins; protein hydrolysis and denaturation; enzymes and how they work; using enzymes to diagnose and treat disease

- Monosaccharides and their cyclic forms
- Lab: Protein Light
- Required Reading: Smith Ch. 16 (16.7–16.11), Ch. 14 (14.1–14.3)

▼ Weekly logistics

- Activity: A31 (16.7–16.11)
- Activity: A32 (14.1–14.3)
- Also this week: Unit Quiz 2 (organic reactions and functional groups); Archer Gallery Visit in place of a lab

Week 7: Carbohydrates and Lipids

What this week covers:

- Reactions of monosaccharides; disaccharides; polysaccharides; blood type
- Lipids — fatty acids, waxes, triacylglycerols, and their hydrolysis
- Lab: Sugar Spill (Day 1); Bioremediation (Day 2)
- Required Reading: Smith Ch. 14 (14.4–14.7), Ch. 15 (15.1–15.5)

▼ Weekly logistics

- Activity: A33 (14.4–14.7)
- Activity: A34 (15.1–15.5)
- Bioremediation lab finishes with a Graphing Workshop

Week 8: Cell Membranes and Nucleic Acids

What this week covers:

- Phospholipids and cell membranes; cholesterol; steroid hormones; fat-soluble vitamins
- Nucleosides, nucleotides, and nucleic acids; the DNA double helix; replication; RNA
- Lab: Bioplastics (Design Challenge)
- Required Reading: Smith Ch. 15 (15.6–15.10), Ch. 17 (17.1–17.5)

▼ Weekly logistics

- Activity: A35 (15.6–15.10)
- Activity: A36 (17.1–17.5)
- Also this week: Unit Quiz 3 (proteins and sugars)

Week 9: Protein Synthesis and Metabolism Overview

What this week covers:

- Transcription; the genetic code; translation; mutations and genetic disease; modern DNA technology; viruses
- Overview of metabolism; ATP and energy production; coenzymes in metabolism
- Lab: DNA Extraction
- Required Reading: Smith Ch. 17 (17.6–17.11), Ch. 18 (18.1–18.3)

▼ Weekly logistics

- Activity: A37 (17.6–17.11)
- Activity: A38 (18.1–18.3)
- Seed-toxicology lab prep begins this week (advance germination time)

Week 10: Catabolism, Energy Expenditure, and Final Project

What this week covers:

- Glycolysis; the fate of pyruvate; the citric acid cycle; electron transport chain and oxidative phosphorylation; ATP yield from glucose
- Catabolism of triacylglycerols; ketone bodies; amino acid metabolism
- Lab: Seed Toxicology
- Final Project: Teach Your Community (TYC) — final exam assessment, 10% of course grade, due Friday, 12/11
- Required Reading: Smith Ch. 18 (18.4–18.11)

▼ Weekly logistics

- Activity: A39 (18.4–18.8)
- Activity: A40 (18.9–18.11)
- Also this week: Unit Quiz 4 (lipids and nucleic acids); Unit Quiz 5 (metabolism); TYC Outline work continues
- Finals week: course potluck